

CORE FORMULA

Formula: breath reset + slightly slower first line + warm interest + clean ending. -> Greeting: "Hey, good to see you." (slower, relaxed, genuine) -> Question: "How has your week actually been?" (curious, not interrogating) -> Request: "Quick ask — could you look at this by Thursday?" (warm but clear) -> Disagreement: "I see the concern. The part I see differently is?" (calm, not sharp)

MINIMUM VIABLE MOVE

Lower the tension, slow slightly, and add warmth to your first sentence before you respond.

BEST FOR

- First impressions, greetings, introductions and re-openings after silence.
- Small talk, rapport, dating or social chemistry, and networking.
- Requests, advice, feedback and disagreement that could otherwise sound blunt.
- Phone calls, voice notes, meetings, interviews and leadership conversations.
- Speaking with shy, guarded, busy, senior or emotionally activated people.
- Recovering when you have sounded rushed, cold, defensive or overly intense.

PHRASE BANK

Greetings / openings · Greetings / openings

- "Hey, good to see you."
- "Nice to see you."
- "I'm glad we got time to talk."
- "Good timing — I wanted to ask you about something."
- "Before we get into it, how are you going?"
- "Good to catch you."
- "Hey — how've you been?"

Warm curiosity · Warm curiosity

- "I'm curious how you're seeing it."
- "What's that been like from your side?"
- "That sounds interesting — how did that come about?"
- "What stood out most?"
- "What's the part people might miss?"
- "Tell me the bit you keep thinking about."

Shy / guarded person · Shy / guarded person

- "No pressure to answer in detail."
- "We can keep this light."
- "Take a second if you need."
- "A rough answer is completely fine."
- "You don't need to have a polished view."
- "Only if you feel like getting into it."

Requests / action · Requests / action

- "Quick ask — could you send that by Friday?"
- "Would you be open to one small thing?"
- "Could I get your view on this? Two minutes is enough."

- "No issue if not, but would you be willing to?"
- "The useful version would be a yes or no by tomorrow."
- "Small favour, and genuinely fine to say no."

High-status / busy person · High-status / busy person

- "I'll keep this brief."
- "Bottom line first?"
- "I've got one concise question."
- "Would thirty seconds be enough for your read?"
- "I can send the short version after this."
- "One decision, then I'll let you go."

Disagreement / feedback · Disagreement / feedback

- "I see why that's the concern."
- "The part I see differently is?"
- "Small correction, because it matters."
- "I don't want this to sound adversarial."
- "Can I offer a different read?"
- "I'm with you on most of this — one part I'd push on."

Digital / voice note · Digital / voice note

- "Keeping this short?"
- "Quick voice note, because tone matters here."
- "No urgency on this."
- "My short version is?"
- "Happy to clarify if this lands oddly in audio."
- "Reading this in a warm voice, not a flat one."

Recovery / reset · Recovery / reset

- "That sounded colder than I meant."
- "Let me say that more plainly."
- "I came in a bit rushed — let me reset."
- "That was sharper than intended."
- "I mean this warmly, not as pressure."
- "I'm trying not to overdo the tone — the simple version is?"

WEAK -> BETTER -> BEST

- Weak: "Hey." (flat, distracted)
Better: "Hey, good to see you."
Best: "Hey, good to see you." — with a small pause and a genuinely relaxed tone.
- Weak: "What?"
Better: "Yeah, what's up?"
Best: "Yeah, of course. What's up?" — with attention and no rush.
- Weak: "Can you do this?"
Better: "Quick ask — could you do this by Friday?"
Best: "Quick ask — could you do this by Friday? No issue if not."
- Weak: "No, I disagree."
Better: "I see the concern. I read it differently."
Best: "I see why that's the concern. The part I see differently is?"
- Weak: Overly sweet: "No worries at all!!!"
Better: "All good."
Best: "All good. Thanks for letting me know."

DECISION TREE

If They warm up

Continue with light curiosity or a brief reflective comment.

""What's that been like from your side?""

If They stay guarded

Reduce intensity, ask less, and make the interaction lower pressure.

""No pressure — we can keep this light.""

If They seem patronised

Drop the warmth down a notch and speak plainly.

""The simple version is?""

If They seem rushed

Lead with the point, warmly, then stop.

""Bottom line first — then I'll let you go.""

If They are upset

Use slower, sober warmth; avoid cheerfulness or forced positivity.

""Okay. I'm with you. Take your time.""

If They ask you to repeat

Increase clarity and volume — don't just get softer.

""Let me say that more clearly.""

If You sound fake to yourself

Reset to plain speech and drop the performance.

""Let me say that more plainly.""

SCENARIOS

First meeting

Start slightly slower, put a smile in the voice, use a simple greeting. — *""Hey, good to meet you.""*

Busy senior person

Warm but concise, no rambling. — *""I'll keep this brief — one quick question.""*

Conflict

Lower the intensity and shorten your sentences. — *""I see the concern. Let's slow this down.""*

Dating or social

Relaxed interest, playful but not performative. — *""That sounds like there's a story there.""*

Voice note

Keep it short and tonally clear. — *""Quick voice note, because this is easier with tone.""*

Apology or repair

Use plain, sober warmth. — *""That came out colder than I meant. Let me try again.""*

WHEN NOT TO USE

- You are using warmth to hide pressure, disappointment or a hidden agenda.
- The situation requires urgency, crisp instruction or safety-critical direction.
- The other person is distressed and your tone tips into cheerful or minimising.
- You are over-softening so much that you lose clarity, authority or self-respect.
- You are performing warmth rather than actually attending to the person.
- Noise or distance calls for more volume and clarity, not more softness.

7-DAY PRACTICE DRILL

Day 1 — Notice your own tone

For one day, do nothing but notice the tone of your first sentence in each interaction. Silently rate each opener: rushed, flat or warm. No changing it yet — just build awareness.

Day 2 — Reset before speaking

Before your first line in five interactions, exhale and drop the tension in your shoulders and jaw. Notice whether the reset changes how the opener lands.

Day 3 — Slow the opener

Slow your first sentence by about ten percent in every greeting today. Check that it sounds present, not theatrical, and pause once after it.

Day 4 — Warm a request

Take three asks you'd normally fire off and deliver each with a warm opener and a clean ending — e.g. "Quick ask — could you?? No issue if not."

Day 5 — Match the moment

Use light warmth on one casual conversation and sober warmth on one serious one. Notice the difference in pace and lift, and whether each fit the mood.

Day 6 — Soften a hard message

Deliver one piece of disagreement or feedback with low-intensity clarity: "I see why that's the concern. The part I see differently is?" Keep the point clear, the tone unhurried.

Day 7 — Calibrate and repair

Through the day, watch for signs your warmth is landing or missing. When it misses, use one recovery line — "That sounded colder than I meant" — and reset the tone.

AFTER-ACTION CHECKLIST

- Did I use the technique because the moment called for it, or because I wanted to perform warmth?
- Was my first sentence slower and less tense than my instinct?
- Did the person have more room after I spoke, or less?
- Did I adjust — plainer, clearer, less soft — when they seemed patronised or confused?
- What neighbouring technique would have been better if this one missed?